

THE NIGHT ROUTE

written by

Magic Hour Sample Unit

Sample five page script for previz feature testing.

Three characters. Six scenes. Four locations.

FADE IN:

INT. DEPOT DISPATCH OFFICE - NIGHT

A small government-issue office lit by one tube light and three CCTV monitors. Rain streaks the window. MAYA RAGHAVAN, 47, dispatcher, sits behind a desk stacked with duty rosters. Everything on the desk is squared to the edge.

In front of her: a single sheet of paper, face down. She turns it face up. ROUTE RATIONALIZATION - EFFECTIVE MONTH END. She turns it face down again.

A knock. RAVI MENON, 58, night bus driver, leans in. Rain jacket, tiffin bag, twenty-two years of night shifts in his posture.

RAVI

Signing in. Bus forty-seven, if she starts.

MAYA

(not looking up)

She'll start. I had the fitter look at her yesterday.

RAVI

You had the fitter look at my bus and not at the canteen kettle. Nine years, Maya. I know where your priorities are.

She slides the sign-in sheet across. He signs without reading it. He always signs without reading it. Her eyes go to the face-down paper, then away.

MAYA

Rain's heavy on the lake road. Take the flyover after stop nine.

RAVI

The flyover adds six minutes.

MAYA

Then be six minutes late. I'll log it as weather.

He studies her a beat too long. She squares the rosters that are already square.

RAVI

Everything all right in headquarters?

MAYA

Go drive your bus, Ravi.

EXT. DEPOT YARD - NIGHT

Rows of parked buses shine under sodium lamps. Rain hammers the tin roof of the wash bay. Ravi crosses the yard, unhurried, the way a man crosses his own courtyard.

By bus 47, ANIL, 24, probationary driver, waits under an umbrella that has given up on one side. He holds a clipboard like it might grade him.

ANIL

Menon sir. They put me with you
for route observation. Three
nights.

RAVI

Observation of what? I drive. The
bus moves. Observation finished.

ANIL

(reading the
clipboard)

Passenger load documentation. They
want counts at every stop on the
night route.

Ravi stops with one foot on the bus step. Counts. He looks back toward the lit window of the dispatch office. Maya's silhouette moves away from the glass.

RAVI

(quietly)

They only count what they plan to
cut.

ANIL

Sir?

RAVI

Get in. Sit where you can see the
mirror. If you're going to count,
count properly.

CUT TO:

INT. BUS 47 (MOVING) - NIGHT

The wipers keep bad time. Four passengers scattered down the aisle: a nurse in scrubs, two market porters asleep on

each other, an old woman with a covered basket. Anil tallies them, twice.

ANIL

Four. Off peak.

RAVI

Wrong. Four people. The nurse gets down at the hospital gate because the day bus doesn't run when her shift ends. Write that in your count.

The radio CRACKLES.

MAYA (V.O.)
(over radio,
filtered)
Forty-seven, position.

RAVI
(into radio)
Passing stop nine. Taking your
flyover. Six minutes of my life
you owe me.

MAYA (V.O.)
Logged as weather. Drive safe.

A pause on the line that lasts longer than dispatch pauses should. Ravi glances at the radio. The click of her signing off sounds like a door being closed gently so no one hears it.

ANIL
Madam Raghavan checks position
every night?

RAVI
Every night, nine years. The night
my daughter was born she found me
a substitute in forty minutes, in
the rain, before mobile phones.
She runs this depot like a watch.

ANIL
Then why does she sound like that?

Ravi doesn't answer. The flyover lights sweep over his face, one by one, like pages turning.

EXT. BUS STOP 14, LAKE ROAD - NIGHT

The last stop before the depot turn. Empty. Rain silvers through the shelter's broken light. The bus stands with its doors open to nobody.

Ravi steps down anyway. Lights a beedi under the shelter. Anil hovers at the door.

ANIL
No one's here, sir. We can go.

RAVI

Schedule says we wait two minutes.
A schedule is a promise. Someone
running through that rain right
now is believing in it.

Two minutes. Nobody comes. Ravi looks at the empty shelter
like an old friend's empty chair, then climbs back up.

INT. DEPOT CANTEEN - DAWN

Steel tables, steam on the tea urn, first light through wire-mesh windows. Maya sits alone with two glasses of tea. One is placed across from her. She has been here a while.

Ravi enters, shift bag over his shoulder, sees the second glass. Sits.

RAVI

The boy counted passengers all night. Wrote the nurse down as a number. I made him rub it out and write her shift timing instead.

MAYA

Ravi.

RAVI

Twenty-two years, Maya. No accident. Not one.

MAYA

(steady, rehearsed)

The night route is being cut at the end of the month. They're moving you to the morning circular. I've known for nine days.

Silence. The tea urn hisses. Ravi turns his glass a quarter turn, then back.

RAVI

Nine days.

MAYA

I kept thinking I could make the numbers say something else. I'm the one who makes the cut look like a schedule. That's my job. Make it look like arithmetic instead of a man.

RAVI

You could have told me the first night.

MAYA

The night my mother died I was on shift and I didn't answer the phone. I know exactly what a person doesn't forgive, Ravi. Being kept in the dark by someone who was right there.

He looks at her. All the anger he brought in finds nowhere to sit.

RAVI

The morning circular. Traffic,
schoolchildren, heat.

MAYA

And you home by six. Your wife
might finally see you eat what she
packs.

RAVI

(half a smile,
despite himself)

She packs for the man who drives
all night. The morning fellow gets
less rice.

Maya laughs once, short, surprised by it. Then her face
steadies.

MAYA

I'm filing an objection. It won't
work. But it will be on paper,
with my name on it. Some things
should cost a signature.

RAVI

You'll sign it the way I sign your
sheet? Without reading?

MAYA

I've read it a hundred times. That
was the problem.

EXT. DEPOT GATE - DAY

Full morning. The rain has stopped. Bus 47 stands washed
and dripping in its bay. Anil, clipboard finally lowered,
watches Ravi walk to the gate.

At the gate Ravi passes Maya's window. He doesn't stop. He
raises the tiffin bag slightly, a small salute. Behind the
glass, Maya raises her tea glass in answer.

Ravi walks out into the traffic and the light, one man in
a city of schedules, all of them promises.

FADE OUT.

THE END